Scientist Network for Advancing Policy (SNAP)
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Policy Hackathon 2026

Policy <> Track I
Environmental & Natural Resources Policy

About This Track:

This challenge is part of the Policy Hackathon 2026 I track: Environment / Conservation. Address a non-carbon environmental problem: pollution, conservation, water quality, or justice.

Use Case Description:

Distinct from the climate/decarbonization track, this challenge asks teams to address a non-carbon environmental problem: pollution, conservation, water quality, or environmental justice.

Problem Statement:

Addressing pollution, conservation, water quality, or environmental-justice problems.

- Select a focus: PFAS/drinking-water contamination, air-quality permitting & environmental justice, public-lands/conservation management, plastics/waste policy, or biodiversity/endangered-species policy.
- Ground the problem in environmental monitoring data (EPA, USGS, state environmental agencies).
- Review existing regulatory tools (Clean Water Act, Clean Air Act, state permitting regimes).
- Design a policy proposal with an enforcement and monitoring mechanism.
- Identify which communities bear the greatest burden (environmental justice lens).

Possible Approaches:

- Regulatory — draft an EPA or state agency rule/permit-reform proposal.
- Community-remediation — center on a specific contaminated site or watershed.
- Market-based — design a conservation easement, cap-and-trade, or mitigation-banking mechanism.
- Environmental-justice — focus on cumulative-impact permitting for overburdened communities.

Challenge Duration:

- Teams start working in September 2026
- Submission on **November 14, 2026**. There will be no extension to the submission deadline.

Team Guidelines:

- Team size — **3–5 participants per team, interdisciplinary encouraged.**
- Ensure you are enrolled as a participant in Policy Hackathon 2026.
- Everyone is eligible to participate in this challenge and win awards.
- Standout teams may be invited to brief partner organizations or judges directly on their proposal.

Challenge Tasks / Deliverables:

- 4–6 page policy brief with monitoring data and recommendation
- One-page fact sheet for a public/community-meeting audience

- Slide deck (8–10 slides)
- A monitoring/enforcement plan showing how compliance would be tracked
- Process appendix (0.5 page)

Optional Advanced Tasks:

- Map affected communities against pollution-burden data (e.g., EPA EJScreen)
- Interview a community member or local official (with consent)
- Draft model permit or rule language
- Cost-benefit analysis of remediation vs. inaction

Platforms and Tools:

- Data: EPA EJScreen, EPA ECHO, USGS, state environmental agency dashboards
- Legislative tracking: Regulations.gov, state legislature sites
- Drafting/collaboration: Google Docs, shared repo

Judging Criteria:

- Scientific/technical accuracy — **25%**
- Environmental justice analysis — **20%**
- Feasibility (regulatory + fiscal) — **20%**
- Clarity of monitoring/enforcement plan — **20%**
- Presentation quality — **15%**

Data Privacy / Eligibility Restriction:

- Use only public environmental monitoring data — no proprietary industry data without permission.
- Consent and anonymization for any community interviews unless attribution is agreed.
- Disclose AI tool use.

Participants retain ownership of their submissions but grant Scientist Network for Advancing Policy (SNAP) the right to evaluate, discuss, and showcase submitted work for educational and research purposes, with appropriate attribution.